DREXEL UNIVERSITY
College of
Computing & Informatics

INFO-102 Introduction to Information Systems

Term Project Specifications
Information Systems Policy Brief

This course examines information systems, including their definitions, functions, and underlying challenges. Students will analyze key issues, contextual factors, and recommend evidence-based solutions. The primary outcome is a **policy brief** intended for stakeholders such as organizational leaders and government policymakers. Drawing on course concepts, scholarly sources, and independent research, students will formulate well-supported recommendations, informed by both user perspectives and emerging professional roles in the design and delivery of information systems.

Some examples of topics chosen in past terms:

- Managing Municipal Aging Infrastructure
- Real-Time Data Extraction in Geographical Information Systems (GIS)
- Impact of Information Technology on False Convictions in the Criminal Justice System
- Barriers to Health Information Data Exchange
- Information Systems and Databases for Natural Disaster Response and Recovery
- Managing and Reducing Human Errors in Workplace
- Integrating global COVID-related information
- Stock Market data
- The FDA drugs repository
- Restaurant Reviews and Inspections
- The IMDB database (movies)
- The House Market (Real Estate)
- Pharma Spend by Nation
- Natural Disasters across the USA
- Philly Historical Parks

Requirements

A. Grouping (3-4 students)
B. The project consists of three components:

C. An initial project proposal: Week 6
D. A PowerPoint presentation: Week 9
E. A 1,200-word paper – Policy Brief: Week 10

Term Project Deliverables and Grading Criteria

INFO-102 Introduction to Information Systems

Milestone #0

- Deadline: Week 1
- Group Forming: Get your group organized and send me an email of all the names of the group members **cc'ing all group members.** Share contacts and schedule meetings.
- Group Norming and Storming: You may experience disagreements as different ideas emerge, and roles are questioned, so it is important that you manage conflicts constructively. As you move forward, you will begin to build trust, align on shared goals, and establish effective ways of working together as a group.
- Group Performing: Get ready on completing all deliverables on time while actively engaging in the process of developing a policy brief that proposes solutions to identified issues in information systems.

Milestone #1 (with PEF)

- Deadline: Week 6 (5 points)
- Submit a term project proposal to describe an identified issue in the broad area of "Information Systems". Your proposal should only include the following items:

  1. The title of the policy brief, for example, "The Impacts of the Semantic Web on Public Libraries".
  2. A paragraph describing the problem and issue you have identified under the title, and reasons you want to write a policy brief about it.
  3. References: Cite at least one reference that you used for preparing the proposal. See Academic Honesty Section / Responsible use of AI Section in the syllabus to acknowledge AI usage.
  4. Submit individual Peer Evaluation Form (PEF)

  Once your proposal is approved, you will continue to write the policy brief and prepare presentation slides.

Rubric:

- Proposed Policy Brief Title (1 pt)
- Context (2 pts)
- At least one Citation (1 pt)
- Overall, Clarity (1 pt)

Milestone #2 (with PEF)

- Deadline: Week 9 – (5 points)
- Term Project Presentation
- You may choose any format or tools that best support your presentation. Present your policy brief along with your research and key findings. Treat this as a business pitch that needs to catch the leader's approval on your recommendations. Additionally, this presentation provides an opportunity to receive feedback from classmates, which can be incorporated into your final policy brief. Each presentation is allotted 5–10 minutes, including Q&A.
- Submit individual Peer Evaluation Form (PEF)

Rubric:

- Attendance on the presentation. day (1 pt)
- Presentation / Delivery. (2 pts)
- Context / Findings (1 pt)
- Overall Impact (1 pt)

Milestone #3 (with PEF)

- Deadline: Week 10 – (10 points)
- Term Project Final Report – 1200-word Policy Brief (PDF document)
  - See attached "INFO 102: Preparing a Policy Brief" for more information.
- Submit individual Peer Evaluation Form (PEF)

Peer Evaluation Form (PEF)

For each group project member, a confidential Peer Evaluation Form must be filled out and submitted when the final project report is submitted. Every group member evaluates himself/herself and each fellow group member for various aspects of the project. Peer evaluations could affect your and your groupmate's grade; thus, it is in your best interest to ensure that these evaluations are conducted fairly. If an individual has taken on extra responsibility, such as organizing the group, extra effort for a particular concept development, editing submissions for consistency, or assembling the whole project components, these activities should be indicated by group members and extra credit will be assigned to that person. Other factors considered are group leadership or ability to plan project and help keep group on track, contribution of each member to the overall project, quality of contribution, development of proposal and problem statement, contribution to the concepts common to all the members. **Without this form, your project grade will be zero.**

INFO 102: Preparing a Policy Brief

You will write a policy brief about one of the topics under the broad title of "Information Systems".

I. Introduction

The policy brief is a neutral summary of what is known about a particular public issue or problem. Specialists prepare documents like this for administrators such as legislators, managers, or other executives who may know little or nothing about the topic but need to be brought up to speed quickly. It doesn't only list facts and details but synthesizes the key points of a policy, the primary actors, and recommendations for future actions. The brief should have a list of references so the audience can have access to the sources on which it is based, and where to go for more information.

II. Parts of the policy brief

Executive Summary (1 point)

This is a single page summary of the purpose of the brief. Each of the main parts of your brief need to be summarized in a separate paragraph. The summary should not be longer than one page and is placed after the cover page.

Section 1. Statement of the problem/issue (2 points)

It is necessary to state the major theoretical viewpoints of this issue clearly and succinctly. There may be more than two main approaches, but the main document should focus on the two most active schools of thought. Within this section, you need to state the problem, identify the generally accepted root causes, and include a reasoned statement about the implications of this problem.

You will need to cite the sources used in your research. A thorough review might require accessing more sources than you actually use. It also means doing more than searching for Google Scholar, knowledge bases or news hubs.

Section 2. Policy's history / Background (2 points)

In order to be able to provide recommendations about the policy at hand, it is necessary to know how and why the issue became a problem. In this section, you will describe the current status quo and the history of how it came to be.

Emergence. When and how did this begin to become an issue, historically? Provide quantitative estimates, if possible, of the problem's magnitude and intensity.
Chronology. List the key dates in the issue development and progression [no more than one page].
Trends. What historical trend data show how the situation evolved? If no data seems to be available, present a method that could be used to track the trends from existing sources.

Section 3: Policy Options (1 point)

This section is where you present your critique of the issue at hand by presenting the advantages and disadvantages of the courses of action available. You may find that it is necessary to identify "missing" or new information needed to understand the issue.

Section 4. Policy recommendations (3 point)
After prioritizing the advantages and disadvantages of the options, you are to recommend one. The recommendation should include reasons why this solution is the best of the available options.

Section 5. References (1 point)
References should be cited according to the 5th edition of the Publication manual of the American Psychological Association (APA Style). List web sites by URL address, then identify sponsor (e.g., "http://www.drexel.edu [Drexel University]"). Please include a recommended readings section if you find other documents that were helpful in the research but not used in the report.

III. Layout
Paper layout: A successful paper of 1200 (minimum) will have the following structure. **Only the BODY OF THE PAPER is included in the word count.**

- Title page
- Executive summary
- Statement of the problem
- Policy's History / Background
- Policy Options
- Policy recommendations
- References

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Instructions for this policy brief assignment were adapted from the following documents:
https://www.courses.psu.edu/hpa/hpa301_fre1/IBInstructions_fa02.PDF
http://www.gse.buffalo.edu/Fas/Jacobson/629/webnotes/policy_brief.htm